



runs Kaizen Academy in Bengaluru.

MMA scene not industry

"MMA in the USA can be considered a sports industry. Right now, there is an MMA scene in India. It's not an industry. It's mostly driven by passion. It's not entirely professional in terms of promotions, fighters, and coaching," says Shillong-based MMA podcaster and commentator Andrew Lu. Crosstrain

founder Siddharth shares a similar view. "What is holding us back is the lack of a big and solid ecosystem where our homegrown athletes have access to the right platforms, the right places to train, the right coaching, the right amateur tournaments to compete in, and the financial support at the right time in their development. We are much better placed than we were a few years ago, but we aren't there yet,"

he admits.

Roshan Mainam, a fighter who has competed at One Championship, adds that only a small proportion of Indian fighters come with skill sets that translate well into mixed martial arts. "One of the major issues I've seen with Indian fighters is that most of us lack a strong wrestling background. If you look at any of the elite international fighters, they usually have a very strong wrestling base. Most of India's top MMA fighters come from a striking background. But no matter how good a striker you are, if you don't have a solid wrestling background, you will always have the fear that the opponent will find a way to take the fight to the ground," says Roshan, who himself competed as a freestyle wrestler in the Indian national championships before transitioning to MMA.

This isn't to say India lacks strong martial arts traditions. It does. But the ability to combine these skills into a style that works well in MMA is still missing. "In India, we have great wrestlers, boxers, and wushu fighters. But very few people have actually combined them all together. I think a lot of this is due to how new the MMA scene is in India. A country like the USA has been able to put everything together for at least the last 25 years. We are still in the first generation of this development. Honestly, we probably have only four or five high-level MMA gyms in India. The rest of the guys are kind of winging it. The academies and coaching need to catch up before we can say we should be rubbing shoulders with the best in the world," says Peeyush.

Even with the right coaching, a talented prospect will likely face another challenge: the lack of the right platform. "One of the biggest problems we face in India is the lack of an actual calendar. No one wants to train without being able to test that training in an actual fight. In the USA, you know that every weekend there's some event or another. The UFC has one event every week, and it's obviously the pinnacle, but there are probably a dozen regional